

As I
Was Saying

BOB INGRAM
SPORTS EDITOR

Pinch-Hitter for Keane

THE DEATH OF JOHNNY KEANE occurred in Houston while the nation's college baseball coaches were holding their annual convention.

Keane was scheduled to take part in a convention clinic conducted for the benefit of both college and high school coaches. His subject was "Bunting and Signals."

Andy Cohen, UTEP's baseball coach, made his first trip to an NCAA convention. He was greeted by Danny Litwhiler, former big leaguer who is now baseball coach at Michigan State. Litwhiler was in charge of the coaches' clinic at the Houston meeting.

They exchanged pleasantries and Danny said: "If I had known you were coming I would have put you on the program. Can you stand by in case some of the speakers don't appear?"

Andy said he would. He didn't know that shortly afterward he would be subbing for Johnny Keane. It was a sad thing to have to do.

Andy filled the job admirably from all accounts. He said: "I felt I was well received by the coaches."

Pinckard Has Own Baseball

THE EL PASO BASEBALL veteran renewed many old acquaintances at Houston. He met ex-players he played with and against and men he managed and managed against.

One of Andy's ex-associates he visited with in Houston was Bill Pinckard, an outfielder for the Texans of the Arizona-Texas League in the Red Sox days of Syd Cohen and Walt Millies.

Pinckard had the power of Arlo Engel without quite as much strikeout frequency as the Sun Kings slugger. But he wasn't as good an outfielder as Engel.

Pinckard played for Andy when the El Pasoan was managing Denver. Pinckard hit a bunch of homers, winning some of the games with his long ball. But his fielding was hopeless and that seems to be the reason for his short career in baseball.

Pinckard now owns or represents a baseball manufacturing plant in Canoga Park, Calif. The company puts out a ball called the "GM" brand. Pinckard was at the NCAA convention selling his ball.

UTEP Season Not Far Off

ANDY SAW a number of his other friends at Houston, including Bill Hicks, a catcher who played for him at Eau Claire in the Northern League. Hicks is now baseball coach at California Poly. Others were Frank Torre, Paul Gregory, Eddie Pellagrini, Dick Siebert and Lee Eilbracht. Pellagrini is the Boston College coach. Siebert is head baseball man at Minnesota and Eilbracht coaches the Illinois diamond team. Torre, brother of Joe Torre of the Atlanta Braves, owns a batting machine.

Closer to El Paso, coaches at Texas (Bibb Falk), Texas Aggies (Tom Chandler) and Arizona State (Bobby Winkles) talked to Cohen.

Andy laid some groundwork for possible future games with schools coached by those men.

All of which means that the baseball season isn't far off. Andy will collect his group of Miners around Feb. 9 or 10 and start practice. The Miners' opening series will be played March 4 and 5 against New Mexico.

Football and basketball teams at UTEP have had great success in recent seasons. Their coaches have done it with scholarship players. Andy's baseball team has been successful too, and has achieved it with virtually no scholarships.